

BUILDING RAPPORT Prime Minister Narendra Modi meeting Qatar's emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani on the sidelines of COP28 in Dubai, Dec. 2023

Indian Foreign Service (IFS) officer was closely monitoring the case and maintained regular contact with the veterans' families as the joint secretary in the Gulf division of the MEA in New Delhi. His prior role as the consul general of India in Dubai added depth to his expertise in the region's affairs.

But India's efforts were dealt a blow on October 26 last year, when the eight men—Captains Navtej Gill and Saurabh Vasisht, Commanders Purnendu Tiwari, Amit Nagpal, S.K. Gupta, B.K. Verma and Sugunakar Pakala, and sailor Ragesh—were awarded death sentences by Qatar's Court of First Instance. This, even as NSA Doval made several trips to Doha in an effort to convince the Qatari authorities about their innocence.

Sources claim the final breakthrough came after Modi met Qatar's emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani on the sidelines of the UN Climate Change Conference, or COP28, in Dubai on December 1. Just two days later, ambassador Vipul got the first consular access to the eight Indians in prison. On December 28, Qatar's Court of Appeal commuted their death penalty, sentencing them to prison for varying durations ranging from three to 25 years. The court also gave the eight men 60 days to appeal against the prison terms.

According to Indian defence officials who talked to INDIA TODAY on the condition of anonymity, all eight veterans had an "impeccable" record before they opted for voluntary retirement. Commander Tiwari, in fact, received the Pravasi Bharatiya Samman in 2019, the highest honour conferred on overseas Indians. Sources suggest possible corporate rivalry behind the whole episode. The eight worked for Dahra Global, a defence services firm set up in 2014 that provided training to the Qatari Emiri Naval Forces. The rival companies, say sources, were envious of its dramatic growth and wanted to discredit it. The company shut its operations in Doha soon after the arrests. Its owner, Khamis Al-Ajmi, a retired Royal Oman Air Force officer and Qatari national, was released on bail in November 2022.

Talking to media after arriving at the Delhi airport, one of the freed navy veterans credited Modi for their safe return. "I feel relieved and delighted to finally be back home, safe and sound," he said, without revealing his name. "I wish to thank Prime Minister Modi as this wouldn't have been possible had it not been for his intervention to secure our release..." The development also marks a significant boost in India's relations with Qatar, which is home to around 800,000 Indian expatriates. Modi's gesture of gratitude will only further strengthen ties. ■

TO THE RESCUE

- **External affairs minister S. Jaishankar led diplomatic efforts with his man on the ground, ambassador Vipul, playing a key role**
- **NSA Ajit Doval carried out behind-the-scenes negotiations and made several trips to Doha**
- **A major breakthrough came after PM Narendra Modi met Qatar's emir in Dubai in December**
- **Modi's rapport with West Asian leaders and India's investments in the region also came in handy**